

ART & CULTURE



INDIAN ARCHITECTURE

MODULE - 9

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

- ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE (CONTD...)

MAURYAN ART AND ARCHITECTURE

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE



- 1 Viharas
- 2 Chaityas
- 3 Stupas
- 4 Pillars and Capitals
- 5 Sculptures
- 6 Rock-cut Caves
- 7 Palaces
- 8 Pottery



ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

5

SCULPTURES



- 1 The dexterity of the Mauryan sculptures is visible in various pillars and capitals, the figures on the railings and gateways of the stupas etc.
- 2 These represent the class of sculptures commissioned by the king.
- 3 Sculptures were primarily used for the decorations of the stupas in the “Thorana and Medhi”, and as a form of religious expression.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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SCULPTURES



4 Two of the famous sculptures of the Mauryan period are those of Yaksha and Yakshinis.

5 They were objects of the worship related to all the three religions - Jainism, Buddhism and Hinduism.

6 The earliest mention of Yakshini can be found in Silappatikaram, a Tamil text.

7 Similarly, all of the Jain Tirthankaras were associated with the Yakshini.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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SCULPTURES

Some of the important sculptures are described here:

DIDARGANJ YAKSHINI



1 This is a life size, free standing statue of a Yakshini discovered in **Didarganj region near Patna** and hence it got its name.

2 It is a masterpiece of sculpture , the sandstone figure shows a Yakshini holding a **Chauri (fly whisk)**.

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SCULPTURES

DIDARGANJ YAKSHINI



3

It is tall and well proportioned. The roundness of face, muscular body and sharp features of nose, lips and eyes are clearly visible.

4

The upper body is bare with a very well-crafted necklace of beads hanging from the neck.

5

The folds of the garment of the lower body are shown by protruding lines creating a transparent effect.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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SCULPTURES

PARKHAM YAKSHA



1 This is another great masterpiece of this period.

2 It is a life-size statue of Yaksha made of red sand stone found near Mathura.

3 The muscular body and the folds of the garments of the lower body are striking.

4 However the statue is not as well preserved as that of the Didarganj Yakshini.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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SCULPTURES

ROCK-CUT ELEPHANT AT DHAULI



- 1 This monumental rock-cut elephant found at **Dhauili in Odisha** is another important specimen of sculpture of this period.
- 2 Built by **Emperor Ashoka**, the elephant is placed above his rock-edict inscribed on which is **Ashoka's concern for the whole World**.
- 3 This place is believed to be sight of the **Kalinga war**.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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ROCK-CUT CAVES



- 1 Caves are important specimens of art and sculpture of ancient India.
- 2 **Chaityas and Viharas** were built in these rock-cut caves. They reflect the culture of that period.
- 3 Many such rock-cut caves have been found throughout India.
- 4 The example of the **Mauryan rock-cut caves** is however limited to **Barabar and Nagarjuni caves** in Bihar, which are the oldest surviving caves of this category.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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ROCK-CUT CAVES

- 5 The outer facade of the Barabar caves has a chaitya arch which is semi-circular.



Lomus Rishi caves in Barabar Hills

- 6 The rectangular interior hall has a circular chamber at the back.

- 7 These chambers are carved out of Granite rock and bear highly polished internal surface.

- 8 Barabar caves was a center of the followers of the Ajivika sect. Also present at the site are several rock-cut Buddhist and Hindu sculptures and inscriptions from later period.

- 9 These caves got the patronage of both emperor Ashoka and Dasharath Maurya.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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ROCK-CUT CAVES



Entrance of the chaitya arch



Highly polished interior of the Barabar caves

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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PALACES

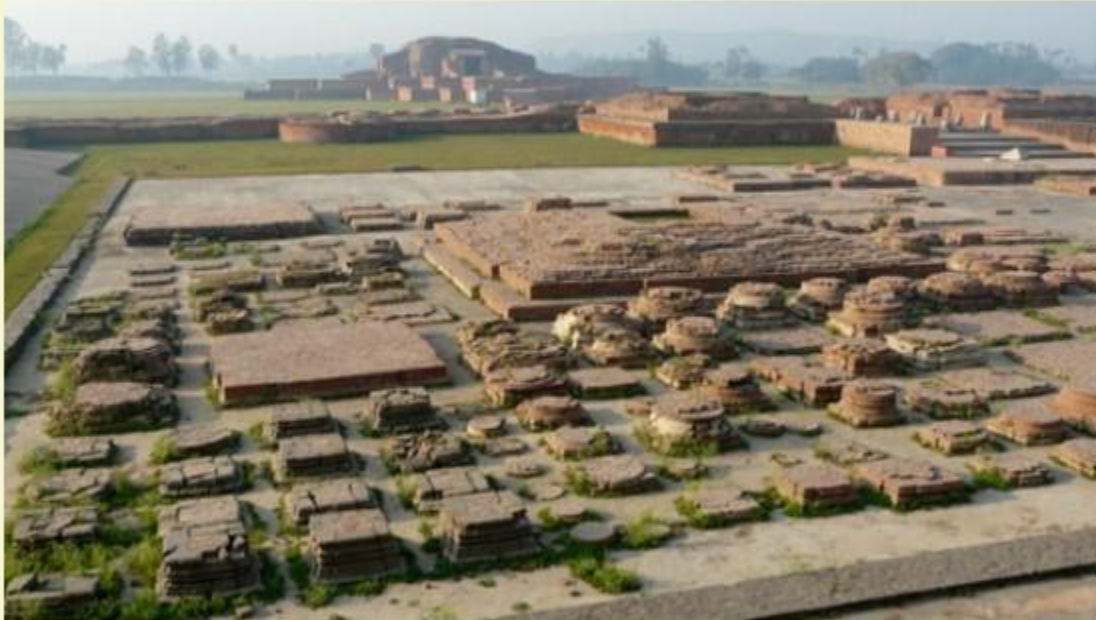


- 1 The Mauryan Empire was the first powerful empire to come to power in India.
- 2 The Mauryan Palaces were another example of the splendour of Mauryan art and architecture.
- 3 The capital at Pataliputra and palaces at Kumrahar were created to reflect the splendour of the Mauryan empire.
- 4 The palace of the Chandragupta Maurya was inspired by the Achaemenid palace in Iran. Wood was the principle building material.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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PALACES



Ruins of the 80 pillared hall in Kumrahar

5

Megasthenes, the Greek ambassador sent by Seleucus Nicator to the Court of Chandragupta Maurya, described the palace as one of the greatest creations of man kind.

6

Similarly, Ashoka's palace at Kumrahar, Patna the remains of which can still be seen had a grand 80 pillared Assembly hall.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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PALACES



Single remaining column of the 80-column hall

7

All the pillars were rock-cut and the remains of a massive pillar of this Assembly hall can still be seen at the site of the palace at Kumrahar.

8

Wooden structures with decorative carvings were plenty and covered the remaining portion of the palace.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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POTTERY



- 1 Pottery on the Mauryan period is generally referred to as **Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)**.
- 2 They were characterized by black paint.
- 3 They have highly lustrous finish and were generally used as luxury items.
- 4 It was made of fine Alluvial clay. It was found in abundance in the Gangetic valley and they were **often referred to as the highest level of pottery**.

ELEMENTS OF MAURYAN ARCHITECTURE

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COINS



- 1 The coins in the Mauryan period were **usually of silver besides a few of copper**.
- 2 These were of various shapes and sizes and carry different figures as that of animals, trees etc.
- 3 The metal was first cut and then the figures were punched.
- 4 These **punch marked coins** represented either royal symbols or the symbols of the local guilds (traders guild who are issuing it).

CAUSES FOR DECLINE OF MAURYAS

1 The causes for the decline of the Mauryan empire have been widely debated by scholars.

2 The traditional approach attributes the decline to **Asoka's policies and his weak successors**.

3 Another approach holds the **inadequate political and economic institutions** to sustain such a vast empire.

4 It was said that **Asoka's pro-Buddhist policies antagonized the Brahmins** who brought about a revolution led by **Pushyamitra Sunga** though there is no clear cut evidence for the above claim.

5 That Asoka's policy of non-violence **reduced the fighting spirit** of his army was another charge against him.

CAUSES FOR DECLINE OF MAURYAS

6 But Asoka had **never slackened his control over his empire** despite following a pacifist policy.

7 Therefore solely blaming Asoka for the decline of the Mauryan empire may not be correct because **Asoka was more a pragmatist than an idealist.**

8 There are multiple causes for the decline of the Mauryan empire such as weak successors, partition of empire and administrative abuses after Asoka's reign.

9 The **combination of these factors speeded up the breakup** of the Mauryan empire and facilitated Pushyamitra Sunga to drive away the Mauryan power and establish the Sunga dynasty.

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